



Preaching in Medieval Florence: The Social World of Franciscan and Dominican Spirituality by Daniel R. Lesnick

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tral undertakings as the edition of the *Libelli de lite* (1891–97, reprint 1956), the Registrum of Gregory VII (1920–23), and the various canon law collections would certainly have served the book's didactic purpose. Nonetheless those undertaking the study of this period and even those well immersed in the topic will find a wealth of information here.

Morris has, in short, created a book that can be a starting point for the student and a source of insight to the scholar. It does not free the beginner of the need to read Fliche and Ullmann, but it lays the ground on which such reading can more comfortably rest.

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LESNICK, DANIEL R. *Preaching in Medieval Florence: The Social World of Franciscan and Dominican Spirituality*. Athens: University of Georgia Press, 1989. 306 pp. \$40.00 (cloth).

Initially, the Dominican and Franciscan orders dedicated their energies to conquering heresy, to promoting clerical reform, and, by relying on vernacular sermons, to making the doctrines of the church and sacred history intelligible to an ignorant laity. They also established tertiary societies and religious companies to encourage lay participation in the defense of the faith. Participants met regularly to sing lauds, stage miracle plays, and perform works of charity. It is often said that Dominican sermons were models of systematic theology aimed at defending orthodoxy, whereas Franciscan sermons stressed feelings of brotherhood, penitence, and mercy. Although Daniel Lesnick does not deny the authenticity of the "religious impulse" that led thousands of individuals to join and to associate with the Dominican and Franciscan orders, he argues that the novelties and meanings of Franciscan and Dominican preaching in Florence in the age of Dante are best understood as both an expression of and response to the social and political developments taking place in the thirteenth and early fourteenth centuries.

During this period, according to Lesnick, Florence and other towns in northern Italy witnessed the eclipse of an entrenched quasi-feudal aristocracy and its ethos of corporatism by two new rival urban classes: the *popolo grasso*, engaged in international commerce, banking, and the production of cloth; and the *popolo*, comprising shopkeepers, artisans, and professionals such as notaries, many of whom had recently migrated to Florence from the countryside. The preaching of the Dominicans and Franciscans, he maintains, helped to soothe the social wounds inflicted by the transformation of Florence from a "Germanic" society of corporate groups that placed a premium on social solidarity to one dominated by enterprise and cash, a society in which "mercantile capitalism" became the determinant of value.

There was a radical difference between the Dominicans and Franciscans, however. Lesnick contends that the majority of Dominicans of Florence were recruited from the ranks of the *popolo grasso*, in direct consequence of which they gave ideological sanction to the political and economic aims of the merchant-banker elite. Grounded in scholastic principles, their sermons emphasized that social dominance was justifiable when tamed by self-discipline; that individualism was acceptable when it did not destroy social tranquility; and that the pursuit of profit and economic prosperity through commerce and banking was morally legitimate, rational, and socially useful so long as it did not violate—or, at least, so long as it paid lip service to—the traditional precepts of hierarchy, brotherhood, justice, and Christian charity undergirding the usury prohibition and the

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doctrine of just price. For their part, the Franciscans of Florence attracted their recruits not from the destitute or from marginalized workers but mainly from the propertied and upwardly mobile members of the *popolo*. Their sermons “taught the urban popolo lessons of action and involvement which would help impel them toward fuller participation in urban society” (p. x).

Lesnick’s characterization of the social composition of the Dominicans and Franciscans and his reduction of mendicant spirituality to the putative needs of social classes, as well as his depiction of the Dominicans as social democrats in medieval garb, are all open to challenge. For one thing, his two social classes lack nuance; they are too neatly defined. For another, then as now it is exceedingly difficult to tell someone’s social status merely from a name or toponymic. In any case, the documentary evidence and tabular information marshaled to support his conclusions are plainly tenuous. There is pertinent archival information in Florence on the Franciscans that Lesnick has either overlooked or decided not to use that would have to be taken into account in any thorough discussion of the social world of that order. The chief source for the Dominicans of Florence is the official necrology of Santa Maria Novella edited by Stefano Orlandi. Using notarial documents that were readily available to Lesnick, though not cited in his book, Emilio Panella (“Quel che la cronica conventuale non dice,” *Memorie Domenicane*, vol. 18 [1987]) has published the names of Florentine Dominicans who do not appear in the official necrology. Their omission was not the result of a *lapis memoriae* but rather of a decision not to commemorate apostates and those who left to join other religious orders. Without knowledge of the rules and practices shaping one’s data, the presentation of tables with numbers labeled as “statistically significant” is a precarious operation. The evidence introduced in support of mendicant social and economic ideology is similarly inadequate. Franciscans and Dominicans produced commentaries on Aristotle’s *Ethics*, tracts on economic issues, and manuals for confessors that have been the object of scholarly investigation and debate. Lesnick’s failure to include primary sources and scholarship so relevant to his theme (studies by Alexander Murray, Guillaume Mollat, Michaud-Quantin, André Vauchez, Odd Langholm, Paolo Grossi, Amleto Spicciati, Ovidio Capitani, Giacomo Todeschini, Roberto Rusconi, et al.) remains inexplicable. Finally, the poetry and stories satirizing the foibles and moral exhibitionism of the mendicants tell us that they regularly fell short of their own professed ideals, while their invectives against the Jews and religious dissidents remind us that they also promoted social and religious intolerance.

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CIGMAN, GLORIA, ed. *Lollard Sermons*. Early English Text Society, Original Series, no. 294. New York: Oxford University Press, 1989. lxx+322 pp. \$59.00 (cloth).

Gloria Cigman has here provided us with our first edition of what internal cross-references establish as a group, now incomplete, of late fourteenth- or early fifteenth-century homiletic texts in English. So far, we know of this group from three manuscripts: London, British Library, Additional MS 41321 (A); Manchester, John Rylands Library, MS Eng 412; and Oxford, Bodleian Library, MS Rawlinson C751 (R). Together, these manuscripts contain sixteen sermons on gospel texts, an optional expansion of one of these (here no. 11A), and the “Ser-